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Kislev: The Architecture of Completion

An excerpt for LinkedIn: the introduction and Chapter Five, "What Is Chanukah?". The full study booklet runs to 92 pages.

כי ה' יהיה בכסלך

Aryeh Leib Thorne Toren

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Prepared on Wednesday, 11 November 2026 (1 Kislev 5787, the second day of Rosh Chodesh Kislev), Jerusalem, in the week of Parashas Toldos.
Not for sale. For study at the table, in the beis midrash and at home.

Prepared in deep partnership and cooperation with Grok and xAI

A note on sources

This LinkedIn excerpt contains only the introduction and Chapter Five, “What Is Chanukah?”. The other chapters, and the six appendices named in the introduction, are in the full 92-page booklet, not in this file.

Every Hebrew quotation in this booklet was cut directly from the text as opened on Sefaria on 11 November 2026, with vowels and cantillation removed. Verses from Tanach are given in the English of *Tanakh: The Holy Scriptures* (Jewish Publication Society, 1985), as published on Sefaria. All other translations are my own working translations, made against the Hebrew printed beside them; the edition used for each text is listed in the Bibliography.

Divine Names. In English this booklet writes G-d, L-rd and Hashem. In Hebrew the Tetragrammaton is printed as ה', the name Elokim as אלקים, and the short two-letter Name as ה'. No Divine Name is printed in full.

Secondary sources. Teachings of the Lubavitcher Rebbe and the Rebbe Rayatz are quoted from the English adaptations named in each place, and Rav Aharon Lichtenstein from the English adaptation of his lecture. The teaching of the Rebbe Rayatz on bitachon in Chapter Three comes from a single secondary source and is marked as such. The Chazon Ish is quoted only as Rav Lichtenstein quotes him.

What was left out. The essay from which this booklet grew contained three claims I could not find in an opened source: a statement attributed jointly to the Chovos HaLevavos and Maharal on bitachon, a summary of the Chazon Ish beyond what Rav Lichtenstein quotes, and a statement that the Rebbe repeatedly instructed a particular study on Zos Chanukah. They are not in this booklet. The saying “Tracht gut, vet zain gut” is also omitted, since I did not open a source for it this time. The essay’s section on academic and political frameworks is not reproduced.

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INTRODUCTION

The Third Month

Why Kislev is the month of light, and how this booklet reads it

Kislev is the third month counted from Tishrei and the month of illumination. This introduction sets out the claim of the booklet, its order, and its link to Parashas Toldos.

The third month

Rosh Chodesh Kislev 5787 was two days this year. The first was Tuesday, 10 November 2026, the thirtieth of Cheshvan. The second is Wednesday, 11 November 2026, the first of Kislev itself. This booklet was finished on that second day.

The Lubavitcher Rebbe opened a talk on this month by counting. The months can be counted from Nissan or from Tishrei. Counted from Nissan, the third month is Sivan, the month of the giving of the Torah at Sinai. Counted from Tishrei, the third month is Kislev. In a talk on Shabbos Parashas Chayei Sarah 5742, as translated and adapted by Yosef Loebenstein, the Rebbe drew the two together: Sivan was the month in which the revealed Torah was given, and Kislev the month in which its hidden dimension was given, on the nineteenth of the month, the day of the Alter Rebbe's release.

The same talk names a single theme for all of Kislev. In Loebenstein's English: "While the month of Kislev contains various concepts, it has one central theme: illumination." Chanukah and the nineteenth of Kislev both mark moments when spiritual darkness gave way to the light of G-dliness.

That theme is the spine of this booklet. Kislev is the month in which darkness is lit up. But the sources that build toward that light are not only about light. They are about trust, about the vessel a person forms before a blessing can rest on it, about sleep and the dreams that come after a day of effort, about a light added night by night until the eighth, and about a reading from the Torah that gathers twelve separate offerings into one dedication.

The architecture of the month

The essay from which this booklet grew, *Kislev as the Architecture of Completion*, published on 10 November 2026, made one claim. The architecture of the month is the progressive turning of potential into actual: the forming of a vessel through ordered effort, and the recognition on the eighth day that the sequence is complete. The booklet tests that claim against the sources. Where a source supports it, I quote the source. Where the essay said more than I could find in an opened text, the booklet says less.

The order is the order of the month.

Chapter One reads Kislev in the Tanach itself: the prophets who received the word of G-d in the ninth month, the day on which Chaggai was told "from this day I will bless," and the midrash that the work of the Mishkan was finished on the twenty-fifth of Kislev.

Chapter Two reads the name of the month. Kislev is linked to kesel, trust, and the sources show that the same root can mean a fool's confidence and a servant's security. Rav Tzadok HaKohen of Lublin makes the link explicit and ties it to the miracle of Chanukah.

Chapter Three asks what trust is, with Rabbeinu Bachya ibn Pakuda's *Shaar HaBitachon* and Rav Aharon Lichtenstein's two kinds of bitachon. It then asks what trust demands of the hands, with the same *Shaar HaBitachon*, a teaching of the Rebbe Rayatz, and Yitzchak sowing in a year of famine in this week's parashah.

Chapter Four turns to the signs of the month in *Sefer Yetzirah*: the letter samech, the bow in the cloud, and sleep. It reads the bow with Rashi and Ramban, and the sleep with the Gemara, the dreams of Vayetzei and Vayeshev, and Rav Tzadok again.

Chapter Five asks the Gemara's question, "What is Chanukah?", and reads the answers of the Gemara and the Rambam. It sets the voice of Yaakov in this week's parashah beside the few who stood against the many.

Chapter Six follows the lights themselves: one, then two, then eight, according to Beis Hillel, and the Rebbe's reading of that dispute as an argument between potential and actual.

Chapter Seven reads the Menorah of Aharon with Rashi and Ramban, and the lights that are never abolished, and sets them beside the verses of light that Jews have long brought to this season.

Chapter Eight reads the Torah portion of Chanukah, the offerings of the Nesi'im, and the eighth day, Zos Chanukah, on which the Nasi of Menashe brings his offering and the whole series is summed as one.

Chapter Nine returns to the nineteenth of Kislev and draws the threads together.

Six appendices follow: a dated calendar for Kislev 5787; the whole Torah reading of Chanukah, Bamidbar 7:1–8:4; both haftaros read on the two Shabbasos of Chanukah this year; Tehillim 30; and a short guide for the family table.

This week: Toldos

This booklet was written in the week of Parashas Toldos, read on Shabbos, 14 November 2026, the fourth of Kislev. Toldos is not a Chanukah parashah. But it is the first parashah of Kislev this year, and it carries two images that run through the month. The first is Yitzchak sowing in a land of famine and finding a hundredfold, and then digging again the wells his father had dug. The second is Yaakov's voice and Esav's hands. Both return in the chapters that follow, where they belong.

How to use this booklet

Each chapter opens with a short summary and closes with questions for the table. The Hebrew of every quoted source is cut directly from the text I opened on Sefaria on 11 November 2026, with vowels removed. The English of verses from Tanach is from the 1985 Jewish Publication Society translation, also opened on Sefaria. The English of the commentaries, the Gemara, the Midrash and the later works is my own working translation, made against the Hebrew printed beside it. Where a teaching comes from a single secondary source, I say so in the text. Where I could not find a claim in an opened source, I left it out.

CHAPTER FIVE

What Is Chanukah?

The Gemara's question, the Rambam's history, and the voice of Yaakov

The Gemara asks of Chanukah a question it asks of no other festival. This chapter reads its answer and the Rambam's fuller account, the Rambam's rule that the Shabbos lamp comes before the Chanukah light, and the Midrash on Toldos about the voice of Yaakov and the hands of Esav.

The Gemara's question

In the middle of the second chapter of Shabbos, among laws about wicks and oils, the Gemara stops and asks a question it asks of no other festival: "What is Chanukah?"

מאי חנוכה? דתנו רבנן: בכ"ה בכסליו יומי דחנוכה תמניא אינון דלא למספד בהון ודלא להתענות בהון. שכשנכנסו יוונים להיכל טמאו כל השמנים שבהיכל. וכשגברה מלכות בית חשמונאי ונצחום, בדקו ולא מצאו אלא פך אחד של שמן שהיה מונח בחותמו של כהן גדול, ולא היה בו אלא להדליק יום אחד. נעשה בו נס והדליקו ממנו שמונה ימים. לשנה אחרת קבעום ועשאום ימים טובים בהלל והודאה

> *What is Chanukah? For the Rabbis taught: On the twenty-fifth of Kislev the days of Chanukah begin; they are eight, on which there is no eulogising and no fasting. For when the Greeks entered the Sanctuary they defiled all the oils in the Sanctuary. And when the kingdom of the house of the Chashmonaim grew strong and defeated them, they searched and found only one cruse of oil that lay with the seal of the Kohen Gadol, and it held only enough to light for one day. A miracle was done with it and they lit from it for eight days. The following year they fixed them and made them festive days, with Hallel and thanksgiving.*
>
> Shabbos 21b

The answer is a quotation from an older text, in Aramaic, that fixes the dates: from the twenty-fifth of Kislev, eight days, with no eulogies and no fasting. Then the story. The Greeks defiled the oils in the Sanctuary. When the house of the Chashmonaim prevailed, they searched and found one cruse sealed with the seal of the Kohen Gadol, enough for one day. A miracle was done, and it lit for eight. The next year the days were fixed as festive days with Hallel and thanksgiving.

Two things stand out. The war is told in a single clause: “when the kingdom of the house of the Chashmonaim grew strong and defeated them.” The oil is told in full. And the festival was fixed “the following year”: not at once, in the heat of victory, but after a year had passed and the meaning had settled.

The Rambam tells the whole story

The Rambam, writing law, tells the history more fully.

בבית שני כשמלכי יון גזרו גזרות על ישראל ובטלו דתם ולא הניחו אותם לעסק בתורה ובמצות. ופשטו ידם בממונם ובבנותיהם ונכנסו להיכל ופרצו בו פרצות וטמאו הטהרות. וצר להם לישראל מאד מפניהם ולחצום לחץ גדול עד שרחם עליהם אלקי אבותינו והושיעם מידם והצילם וגברו בני חשמונאי הכהנים הגדולים והרגום והושיעו ישראל מידם והעמידו מלך מן הכהנים וחזרה מלכות לישראל יתר על מאתים שנה עד החרבן השני

In the Second Temple, when the kings of Greece issued decrees against Israel, abolished their religion, and did not let them occupy themselves with Torah and mitzvos; they stretched out their hands against their property and their daughters, entered the Sanctuary, made breaches in it and defiled what was pure. Israel was in great distress because of them, and they oppressed them greatly, until the G-d of our fathers had mercy on them, saved them from their hand and rescued them. The sons of the Chashmonai, the Kohanim Gedolim, prevailed, killed them and saved Israel from their hand; and they set up a king from the Kohanim, and kingship returned to Israel for more than two hundred years, until the second destruction.

Rambam, Mishneh Torah, Hilchos Megillah vaChanukah 3:1

The decrees came first: Torah and mitzvos forbidden, property and daughters seized, the Sanctuary breached and the pure things defiled. The Rambam does not soften it: Israel was in great distress. Then the turn, “until the G-d of our fathers had mercy on them.” The sons of the Chashmonai, the Kohanim Gedolim, prevailed and saved Israel, and kingship returned to Israel for more than two hundred years.

Then the date and the oil.

וכשגברו ישראל על אויביהם ואבדום בכ"ה בחדש כסלו היה ונכנסו להיכל ולא מצאו שמן טהור במקדש אלא פך אחד ולא היה בו להדליק אלא יום אחד בלבד והדליקו ממנו נרות המערכה שמונה ימים עד שכתשו זיתים והוציאו שמן טהור

When Israel prevailed over their enemies and destroyed them, it was on the twenty-fifth of the month of Kislev. They entered the Sanctuary and found no pure oil in the Mikdash except one cruse, and it had only enough to light for one day alone; and they lit the lamps of the arrangement from it for eight days, until they crushed olives and brought out pure oil.

Rambam, Hilchos Megillah vaChanukah 3:2

The victory and the entry into the Sanctuary are on the twenty-fifth of Kislev. One cruse, enough for one day, lit for eight, until they crushed olives and made new pure oil. The Rambam adds the practical detail the Gemara leaves out: the eight days were the time it took to make new oil. The miracle covered the gap between what they had and what they could produce.

Then the law.

> ומפני זה התקינו חכמים שבאותו הדור שיהיו שמונת הימים האלו שתחלתן כ"ה בכסלו ימי שמחה והלל ומדליקין בהן הנרות בערב על פתחי הבתים בכל לילה ולילה משמונת הלילות להראות ולגלות הנס
>
> *Because of this the Sages of that generation ordained that these eight days, beginning on the twenty-fifth of Kislev, should be days of joy and Hallel, and that lights be kindled on them in the evening at the doors of the houses, on each of the eight nights, to show and reveal the miracle.*
>
> Rambam, Hilchos Megillah vaChanukah 3:3

The Sages of that generation fixed eight days of joy and Hallel, with lights kindled in the evening at the doors of houses, “to show and reveal the miracle.” The lights are not for the people inside. They are for the street.

The miracle and the war

The two accounts emphasise different things, and both are true. The Gemara asks what the festival is, and answers with the oil. The Rambam gives the war, the restored kingship, and the oil. Rav Tzadok, in Chapter Two, joined them: the war was a miracle of trust, a handful against an empire, and it happened in the month named for trust.

There is a reason the festival is kept with lights rather than with a feast of victory. The Chanukah prayer, Al HaNissim, thanks G-d that He “delivered the mighty into the hands of the weak and the many into the hands of the few.” The emphasis falls on who did the delivering. The war was fought by men; the victory is credited to G-d. The lights carry that emphasis into every home. They show that the outcome was not the product of the swords, as Rabbeinu Bachya would put it, but of the One who stood behind the hands that held them.

The most beloved mitzvah

The Rambam closes the laws of Chanukah with words of unusual warmth.

מצות נר חנכה מצוה חביבה היא עד מאד וצריך אדם להזהר בה כדי להודיע הנס ולהוסיף בשבח ה' והודיה לו על הנסים שעשה לנו. אפלו אין לו מה יאכל אלא מן הצדקה שואל או מוכר כסותו ולוקח שמן ונרות ומדליק

The mitzvah of the Chanukah light is an exceedingly beloved mitzvah, and a person must be careful with it, in order to make the miracle known and to add to the praise of G-d and thanksgiving to Him for the miracles He did for us. Even if he has nothing to eat except from tzedakah, he borrows, or sells his garment, and buys oil and lamps and lights.

Rambam, Hilchos Megillah vaChanukah 4:12

"An exceedingly beloved mitzvah." A poor man supported by tzedakah must borrow or sell his garment to buy oil. The reason is in the same sentence: to make the miracle known, and to add to the praise of G-d. The Shulchan Aruch codifies the same rule, almost word for word.

צריך ליזהר מאוד בהדלקת נרות חנוכה ואפילו עני המתפרנס מן הצדקה שואל או מוכר כסותו ולוקח שמן להדליק

One must be very careful with the kindling of the Chanukah lights; even a poor man supported by tzedakah borrows, or sells his garment, and buys oil to light.

Shulchan Aruch, Orach Chaim 671:1

And then the Rambam sets one limit, and it is a limit of peace.

היה לפניו נר ביתו ונר חנכה או נר ביתו וקדוש היום נר ביתו קודם משום שלום ביתו שהרי השם נמחק לעשות שלום בין איש לאשתו. גדול השלום שכל התורה נתנה לעשות שלום בעולם שנאמר (משלי ג יז) "דרכיה דרכי נעם וכל נתיבתיה שלום

If he has before him the light of his house and the Chanukah light, or the light of his house and Kiddush, the light of his house comes first, because of the peace of his home; for the Name is erased to make peace between a man and his wife. Great is peace, for the whole Torah was given to make peace in the world, as it says (Mishlei 3:17), "Her ways are pleasant ways, and all her paths, peace."

Rambam, Hilchos Megillah vaChanukah 4:14

If a person can afford only one light, the light of his house, the Shabbos lamp, comes before the Chanukah light, "because of the peace of his home." The Rambam's reason is a principle that reaches beyond Chanukah: the Name itself may be erased to make peace between husband and wife, and the whole Torah was given to make peace in the world. The most beloved public mitzvah gives way to a lamp that lets a family see each other at their own table.

This is a quiet correction to any reading of Chanukah as a festival of triumph alone. The light that publicises the miracle in the street matters enormously. The light that keeps peace inside matters more.

This week: the voice of Yaakov

Parashas Toldos holds the verse the Sages read as the key to Jewish strength.

> ויגש יעקב אל־יצחק אביו וימשהו ויאמר הקל קול יעקב והידים ידי עשו

So Jacob drew close to his father Isaac, who felt him and wondered. "The voice is the voice of Jacob, yet the hands are the hands of Esau." (JPS)

Bereishis 27:22

Blind Yitzchak touches his son and is puzzled. The voice is Yaakov's; the hands feel like Esav's. The Midrash reads the verse as a statement about two kinds of power.

> הקל קול יעקב, אין יעקב שולט אלא בקולו, הקל קול יעקב והידים ידי עשו, אין עשו שולט אלא בידים. דבר אחר, הקל קול יעקב, אמר רבי פנחס קולו של יעקב מכניס, והידים ידי עשו, מרמז ליה והוא אתי. דבר אחר, הקל קול יעקב, אמר רבי ברכיה בשעה שיעקב מרכין בקולו, ידי עשו שולטות, דכתיב (שמות טו, כד): וילנו כל העדה, (שמות יז, ח): ויבא עמלק, ובשעה שהוא מצפצף בקולו אין הידים ידי עשו, אין ידי עשו שולטות

"The voice is the voice of Yaakov": Yaakov rules only by his voice. "The voice is the voice of Yaakov, and the hands are the hands of Esav": Esav rules only by the hands. Another explanation: … Rabbi Berechiah said: When Yaakov lowers his voice, the hands of Esav rule, as it is written, "And the whole community murmured" (Shemos 15:24), and then, "Amalek came" (Shemos 17:8). And when he chirps with his voice, the hands are not the hands of Esav; the hands of Esav do not rule.

Bereishis Rabbah 65:20 (one interpretation omitted)

Yaakov rules by his voice; Esav rules by his hands. When Yaakov lowers his voice, Esav's hands prevail. When Yaakov raises his voice, Esav's hands do not rule. The voice, in the Midrash that follows, is the voice of children learning Torah.

> לכו וחזרו על בתי כנסיות ועל בתי מדרשות שלהן, ואם מצאתם שם תינוקות מצפצפין בקולן

[Avnimos of Gadara told the nations:] Go around their synagogues and their study houses; if you find children chirping with their voices there …

Bereishis Rabbah 65:20

The nations, the Midrash says, asked the wisest of their philosophers how they might overcome Israel. He told them to go round the synagogues and study houses. If they found children there chirping with their voices, they could not prevail.

This is not a teaching against the hands. Yaakov in this very parashah works, deals, flees and later fights an angel. The Chashmonaim fought with their hands. The teaching is about what decides the contest. When the voice of Torah is raised, the hands of Esav do not rule. The Chashmonaim went out to war in order to restore the Torah the Greek decrees had banned. The voice came first, and the war served the voice.

Two nations in one womb

Toldos opens with the struggle in Rivkah's womb.

> ויתרצצו הבנים בקרבה ותאמר אם־כן למה זה אנכי ותלך לדרש את־ה' ויאמר ה' לה שני גוים בבטנך ושני לאמים ממעיך יפרדו ולאם מלאם יאמץ ורב יעבד צעיר
>
> *But the children struggled in her womb, and she said, "If so, why do I exist?" She went to inquire of the L-RD, and the L-RD answered her, "Two nations are in your womb, Two separate peoples shall issue from your body; One people shall be mightier than the other, And the older shall serve the younger." (JPS)*
>
> Bereishis 25:22–23

Rashi brings the midrash that made the struggle a contest of directions.

> רבותינו דרשוהו לשון ריצה; כשהיתה עוברת על פתחי תורה של שם ועבר יעקב רץ ומפרכס לצאת, עוברת על פתח עבודת אלילים, עשו מפרכס לצאת
>
> *Our Rabbis expounded it as the language of running: when she passed by the doors of the Torah of Shem and Ever, Yaakov ran and struggled to come out; when she passed by the door of idol worship, Esav struggled to come out.*
>
> Rashi on Bereishis 25:22

When she passed the study house of Shem and Ever, Yaakov struggled to come out; when she passed a place of idol worship, Esav struggled to come out. Two directions in one body, from before birth. The prophecy Rivkah received said that one would be stronger than the other, and that the elder would serve the younger.

The story of Chanukah is told by the Rambam as the story of a people under a foreign power that tried to cut it off from Torah and mitzvos. The parashah of this week says that the struggle between those two directions is as old as the womb. And Kislev, as the Rebbe put it, is the month of illumination: not the month in which darkness disappears, but the month in which it is lit up.

What the question teaches

"What is Chanukah?" The Gemara answers with a cruse of oil. The Rambam answers with a war, a kingship, a cruse of oil and a law of lights at the door. Rav Tzadok answers

with trust. The Midrash on Toldos answers, in its own way, with a voice. Put together: Chanukah is the festival of a few who trusted, fought, restored the voice of Torah, and found that what they had was enough to last until they could make more.

For the table

1. The Gemara tells the war in one clause and the oil in full. Why might the Sages have chosen to remember Chanukah through the oil?
2. The festival was fixed “the following year.” What is gained by waiting a year before deciding what an event means?
3. The Rambam puts the Shabbos lamp, for peace at home, before the Chanukah light. What does that teach about public and private light?
4. The Midrash says Esav’s hands rule when Yaakov’s voice is lowered. What is the “voice of Yaakov” in your home?

Glossary

Alter Rebbe. Rabbi Schneur Zalman of Liadi (1745–1812), founder of Chabad, author of the *Tanya*.

Avudraham. Rabbi David Avudraham (fourteenth century, Seville), author of a commentary on the prayers.

Beis Hillel, Beis Shammai. The schools of Hillel and Shammai, the great disputants of the Mishnah; the halachah usually follows Beis Hillel.

Bitachon. Trust in G-d.

Chashmonaim. The priestly family of Matisyahu and his sons, who led the revolt against the Greek kingdom and rededicated the Beis HaMikdash.

Chassidus. The teaching of the Baal Shem Tov and his successors; in Chabad, its systematic exposition by the Alter Rebbe and his successors.

Hayom Yom. A calendar of daily teachings compiled by the Lubavitcher Rebbe in 1942–1943 from the talks and letters of the Rebbe Rayatz.

Hefkeirus. Irresponsibility; abandoning a matter to chance.

Hishtadlus. Human effort; the natural means a person takes.

Kesel. Confidence, trust; also folly. The root of the name Kislev, according to Rav Tzadok.

Keshet. Bow; the rainbow of Bereishis 9; the constellation of Kislev in *Sefer Yetzirah*.

Kli. A vessel; in Chassidus, the natural means through which a blessing comes.

Maggid of Mezritch. Rabbi Dov Ber (died 19 Kislev 5533, 1772), successor to the Baal Shem Tov and teacher of the Alter Rebbe.

Mishkan. The portable Sanctuary of the wilderness.

Nasi, Nesi'im. Chieftain of a tribe; the twelve chieftains who brought the dedication offerings of the altar (Bamidbar 7).

Pri Tzadik. Teachings on the parashiyos and festivals by Rav Tzadok HaKohen of Lublin (1823–1900).

Rambam. Rabbi Moshe ben Maimon (1138–1204), author of the *Mishneh Torah*.

Ramban. Rabbi Moshe ben Nachman (1194–1270), Gerona and the Land of Israel, commentator on the Torah.

Rashi. Rabbi Shlomo Yitzchaki (1040–1105), Troyes, the foundational commentator on Tanach and Talmud.

Rebbe Rashab. Rabbi Shalom DovBer Schneersohn (1860–1920), fifth Lubavitcher Rebbe.

Rebbe Rayatz. Rabbi Yosef Yitzchak Schneersohn (1880–1950), sixth Lubavitcher Rebbe.

Samech. The fifteenth letter of the alef-beis, closed in shape; the letter of Kislev in *Sefer Yetzirah*.

Sefer Yetzirah. The Book of Formation, an ancient work on the letters as the elements of creation, extant in several versions.

Shaar HaBitachon. The Gate of Trust, the fourth gate of *Chovos HaLevavos* by Rabbeinu Bachya ibn Pakuda (eleventh century, Spain).

Zos Chanukah. The eighth day of Chanukah, named for the words "Zos chanukas hamizbe'ach" in its Torah reading.

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